Confusing Words	Definitions and Examples
that, which	*That* is used to introduce information essential to the meaning of a sentence. *The phone that I bought five years ago no longer charges fully. Which* is most often used to introduce information that is nonessential to the meaning of a sentence. *My iPhone 7, which I bought five years ago, no longer charges fully.* (For more on nonessential and essential information, see Editing Focus: Commas with Nonessential and Essential Information.)
that, who, which	Use *that* and *which* to refer to things and most animals. *The tiger that had escaped was found.* Use *who* to refer to people and animals with names. *Doctors who treated COVID-19 patients were often called heroes.*
their, there, they're	*Their* is a possessive pronoun. *There* indicates place. *They're* is a contraction of "they are." *The Smiths rescued their missing cat from that tree over there; they're happy to have him back.*
to, too, two	*To* can be a preposition indicating direction. *I am going to the pool.* Or it can be part of an infinitive (the *to* form of a verb). *I like to swim. Too* means "also" or "excessively." *Do you like to swim too? Two* is a number. *I swim two times every week.*
unique, unusual	*Unique* means "one of a kind." *Unusual* means "uncommon." Saying that something is more unique than something else is incorrect because something unique cannot be compared. Use *unusual* instead when comparing.
weather, whether	*Weather* refers to the state of the atmosphere. *Whether* refers to alternatives. *Whether we attend the game in person or watch it on TV depends on the weather.*
who's, whose	*Who's* is the contraction of "who is" or "who has." *Who's going to the game? Whose* is the possessive form of "who." *Whose backpack is this?*
your, you're	*Your* is the possessive form of "you." *You're* is the contraction of "you are." *You're going to be relieved that I found your earring behind the desk.*

TABLE H4

H 6. Point of View

Point of view refers to the vantage point from which a story, event, report, or other written work is told. The point of view in which you write depends on the genre in which you are writing. For example, you will likely use first person in personal narrative writing. For most academic writing, you'll use third person. (See Editing Focus: Characterization and Point of View for a related discussion of point of view in narrative writing.)

First Person

In the first-person point of view, the writer or narrator (*I, we*) is present in the writing. First person is commonly used in personal writing genres, such as literacy narratives, memoirs, and profiles, as well as in fiction.

> After midnight—my paper started, my exam studied for—I leave the library and head back to my apartment. In the dark, I listen closely when I hear footsteps behind me, and I step to the edge of the sidewalk to let a man pass. At my door, I fumble for my key, open the door, turn on the light, and step inside. I am safe, ready to eat, read a bit, and return to my paper.

Second Person

Second-person point of view is used occasionally when an outsider (*you*) becomes part of a story. It should not be confused with a writer or speaker using "you" when directly addressing an audience (*you*). Nor should it be confused with giving instructions (*drive forward, add one cup of brown sugar, close the door*) or with its similar use in textbooks such as this one. However, second person is not considered appropriate in most academic writing.

Writers often slip into second person when they intend to write in third person. In the example below, the writer starts in third person and shifts by accident to second person. To check your sentences for second person, search your documents for *you*, and revise as needed.

> **Shift from Third Person to Second Person** The federal government should raise the minimum wage because it has the responsibility to ensure people earn a wage you can live on. The current minimum wage, $7.25 per hour, is not enough to pay rent, let alone support a family. Many people cannot lift themselves out of poverty. A higher minimum wage can help you.
>
> **Revised** The federal government should raise the minimum wage because it has the responsibility to ensure workers earn a wage they can live on. The current minimum wage, $7.25 per hour, is not enough to pay a single person's rent, let alone support a family. Many people cannot lift themselves out of poverty. A higher minimum wage can help them.

Third Person

The third-person point of view (*he, she, it, they*) is customary for fiction and for academic writing, such as research papers, reports, visual and textual analysis papers, argumentative essays, and the like. Third-person point of view emphasizes the information instead of the writer.

> The hikers and other passive trail users argue that mountain bikes should not be allowed on narrow trails traditionally traveled by foot and horse. They point out that the bikes' wide, treaded tires cause erosion, that the bikers' high speeds startle hikers and horses, and that their presence on trails disrupts the tranquility that hikers and bird watchers seek.

H 7. Verbs

In a sentence, a verb expresses an action, an occurrence, or a state of being.

Subject-Verb Agreement

In many sentences, making the verb agree with the subject is straightforward: *I run every day. My sister runs every other day. Sometimes our brother joins us, and all of us run together.* However, subject-verb agreement gets tricky in the following circumstances. (See Editing Focus: Subject-Verb Agreement for more on subject-verb agreement.)

Agreement with Compound Subjects

Two or more subjects joined by *and* take a plural verb in most sentences:

> Yoga and meditation are effective activities for relieving stress.

However, when the parts of the subject form a single idea or unit, the verb is singular:

> Macaroni and cheese is my favorite meal.

When compound subjects are joined by *or* or *nor,* the verb agrees with the word closest to it:

> Either your aunts or your mother remembers where your great-grandmother's grave is located.
>
> Neither the image nor the words convey the message of the advertisement clearly.